

Is Beauty in the Object or the Eye? A Guided Tour of Theories of Beauty

An original lesson plan inspired by **Crispin Sartwell's** the *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy* entry on *Beauty*. Not affiliated with or endorsed by *Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy* or *Crispin Sartwell*. Explore the original course: <https://plato.stanford.edu/entries/beauty/>

GRADE LEVEL

Grades 11-12 / Intro College

DURATION

60 minutes

TOPICS

Aesthetics

“Is beauty a real property that objects have independently of anyone noticing them — like mass or shape — or is it something that exists only in the response of a perceiver, and can any theory of beauty really split the difference?”

Learning Objectives

By the end of this lesson, students will be able to:

- Distinguish objectivist theories of beauty (beauty as a mind-independent property, such as proportion or harmony) from subjectivist theories (beauty as a response or feeling in the perceiver).
- Explain how Hume's standard of taste and Kant's account of the judgment of taste each attempt to preserve some form of universal agreement about beauty without treating it as a simple physical property.
- Apply objectivist, subjectivist, and hybrid theories to a contested real-world case and construct a defensible position about which theory explains it best.

Materials Needed

- A set of 5-6 printed or projected images spanning very different kinds of beauty (a natural landscape, a classical sculpture, a human face, an abstract painting, an ordinary object like a chair)
- Handout summarizing four positions: classical objectivism (proportion/harmony), Humean subjectivism ('Of the Standard of Taste'), Kant's account of the judgment of taste, and evolutionary/desire-based theories
- Whiteboard or chart paper for recording the class's initial rankings
- Index cards for the anonymous ranking activity

Lesson Procedure

Hook: Rank the Images

10 min

Show the 5-6 images and ask each student to silently rank them from most to least beautiful on an index card, along with one word explaining their top choice. Tabulate the rankings on the board without discussion yet. Note aloud that there will likely be real disagreement, especially about the abstract painting and the ordinary object — this sets up the day's central tension.

Direct Instruction: Objectivism vs. Subjectivism

15 min

Introduce classical objectivism, the view (traceable to Pythagoras and developed by Plotinus) that beauty is a real, mind-independent property tied to proportion, symmetry, and harmony among parts. Contrast this with subjectivism, the view that calling something beautiful just reports a pleasurable response in the observer, with no further fact about the object required. Ask students which view better explains their own rankings from the hook.

Direct Instruction: Hume's and Kant's Middle Paths

15 min

Introduce Hume's proposal that while beauty is a felt response, not every response is equally reliable — a 'true judge' needs delicacy of sensation, practice, comparison across many works, and freedom from prejudice, so some verdicts genuinely outrank others. Then introduce Kant's more radical claim that judgments of beauty are grounded purely in subjective pleasure yet nonetheless demand universal agreement from everyone, without appeal to a concept or rule. Chart both alongside objectivism and subjectivism on the board.

Small-Group Case Application

13 min

In groups of three, students pick one image from the hook that produced the most disagreement and argue how each of the four positions (objectivism, subjectivism, Hume, Kant) would explain the disagreement — does it mean someone is simply wrong, that both are right, or that one judge is more qualified than the other? Groups record their strongest and weakest theory for that specific case.

Closure: Revised Vote and Debate

7 min

Reveal the class's original rankings again and ask whether anyone wants to revise their ranking after the discussion. Take a quick vote on which theory (objectivism, subjectivism, Hume, or Kant) the class finds most persuasive overall, and ask one or two dissenters to defend their choice in a sentence.

Discussion Questions

- 1 If beauty were purely objective, like mass or temperature, how would we explain the persistent and sometimes deep disagreements about it that exist both across cultures and within your own classroom?
- 2 If beauty is purely subjective, is it strange that people argue about it at all, as though someone could actually be wrong? What do those arguments suggest about how we really treat aesthetic judgments?
- 3 Hume says a 'true judge' of taste needs delicacy, extensive comparison, and freedom from prejudice — does this genuinely rescue objectivity, or does it just relocate the disagreement to who counts as a qualified judge?
- 4 Kant claims a judgment of beauty is grounded in a private feeling of pleasure yet still demands that everyone else agree with it. Is that combination actually coherent, or is Kant trying to have it both ways?

- 5 Does an object's usefulness or function (like the chair) change whether or how we can call it beautiful, compared to something with no function at all, like a landscape?

Assessment

Students write a one-page position paper in which they select one image or object discussed in class and defend, using specific concepts from at least two of the four theories covered, whether its beauty is best explained as an objective property, a subjective response, or some hybrid of the two. Grade for clarity of argument and accurate use of the theories' vocabulary, not for which position the student ultimately takes.

Extension Activity

Have students find two online reviews or critical responses to the same artwork, film, or piece of music that sharply disagree about its beauty or quality, and write a short analysis of which of the four theories from class best explains the disagreement — and whether the disagreement can be resolved at all under that theory.

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